English Words in Bollywood Song Lyrics: A Linguistic Analysis

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Introduction

Bollywood cinema represents one of India's most influential cultural exports, with its songs often featuring linguistic hybridity through the incorporation of English words into predominantly Hindi lyrics. This linguistic phenomenon reflects broader patterns of language contact in a post-colonial context where English holds significant prestige and functions as a language of modernity and globalization. What began as occasional borrowing has developed into more complex patterns of code-switching that serve various artistic, communicative, and commercial purposes.

As Chamundeshwari and Iqbal (2019) note, "Code-switching in Indian film songs reflects not just linguistic choices but cultural identities and social aspirations."

Research Questions:

- What are the patterns of English lexical borrowing versus code-switching in contemporary Bollywood song lyrics?
- Which grammatical categories are most represented in these incorporations?
- What semantic domains are most frequently expressed through English words?
- What functions might these patterns serve in the context of Bollywood music?

Methodology

Data Collection: The data for this study consists of 233 English words extracted from 36 Bollywood songs. The songs were selected to represent contemporary Bollywood music, with attention to popularity and linguistic diversity. Each song was manually analyzed to identify English words embedded within the predominantly Hindi lyrics.

Classification System:

Part of Speech: 25+ grammatical categories including simple categories (Noun, Verb, Pronoun, etc.) and compound categories (Noun/Verb, Verb/Adjective, etc.)

Code-Switching vs. Borrowing:

Borrowing: Words integrated into Hindi usage, with possible phonological adaptation

Code-Switching: Temporary shift to English maintaining its phonology & morphology

Semantic Categorization: 13 domains including Person/Identity, Action/Movement, Objects/Things, Life/Philosophy, etc.

Analysis Approach: Frequency distributions and cross-tabulations between variables

Analysis & Results

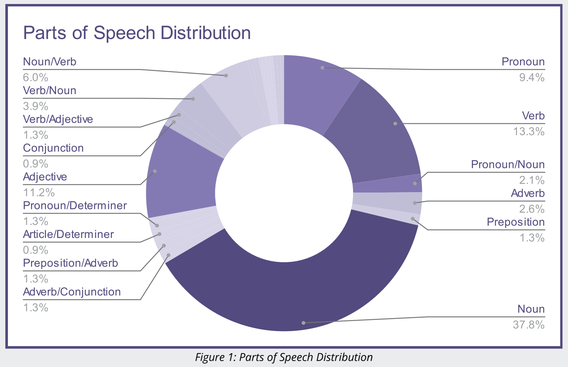


Figure 1: Parts of Speech Distribution

- **Nouns** dominate the corpus at **37.8%**, supporting previous research findings that nouns are typically the most commonly borrowed or switched elements in language contact situations.
- **Pronouns** represent the second largest category at **34.1%**, which is notably high compared to typical borrowing patterns.
- **Verbs** constitute **13.3%** of the corpus, representing a significant category that often indicates more profound language mixing since verbs typically require greater grammatical integration.
- **Adjectives** account for **11.2%**, showing that English is frequently used for descriptive functions, potentially exploiting connotative meanings that may differ from Hindi equivalents.

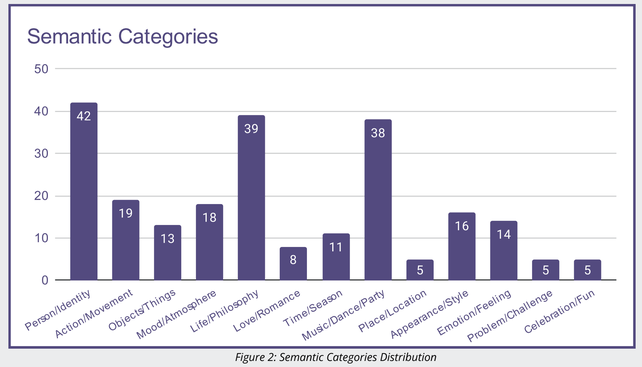


Figure 2: Semantic Categories Distribution

Person/Identity (42 occurrences): This dominance suggests that English is frequently employed to express concepts related to self, others, and identity constructs.

Life/Philosophy (39 occurrences): The high frequency in this category indicates that thoughtful phrases and expressions are preferentially maintained in English.

Music/Dance/Party (38 occurrences): The significant presence of English in this domain reflects the global nature of contemporary music culture and its terminology.

Action/Movement (19 occurrences) and Mood/Atmosphere (18 occurrences): These moderately represented categories suggest that abstract concepts and dynamic actions are also expressed through English, though less frequently than the top three.

The least represented categories—Problem/Challenge (5 occurrences), Celebration/Fun (5 occurrences), and Place/Location (5 occurrences)—indicate domains where Hindi expressions may be preferred or considered more authentic.

Code Switching:

58.8%

Borrowing:

41.2%

The analysis of 233 English words from the 36 Bollywood songs revealed that code-switching (58.8%) occurs more frequently than borrowing (41.2%).

This suggests that lyricists are more likely to deliberately switch to English for stylistic or communicative purposes rather than using established loan words that have become part of Hindi vernacular.

Categories with Dominant Code Switching:

- **Life/Philosophy:** Shows the highest frequency of code switching (~32 instances), with minimal borrowing (~3).
- **Action/Movement:** Shows significantly more code switching (~19) than borrowing (almost none), indicating that action verbs are typically used as stylistic English switches.
- **Person/Identity:** Shows more code switching (~23) than borrowing (~17), suggesting that identity terms often involve deliberate switching to English.

Categories with Dominant Borrowing:

- **Music/Dance/Party:** Shows the highest borrowing frequency (~22) with moderate code switching (~15), suggesting that music and entertainment terminology is often integrated into Hindi.
- **Appearance/Style:** Shows higher levels of borrowing (~12) than code switching (~5), suggesting integrated usage.
- **Emotion/Feeling:** More borrowing than code switching for words like love, feel, etc.

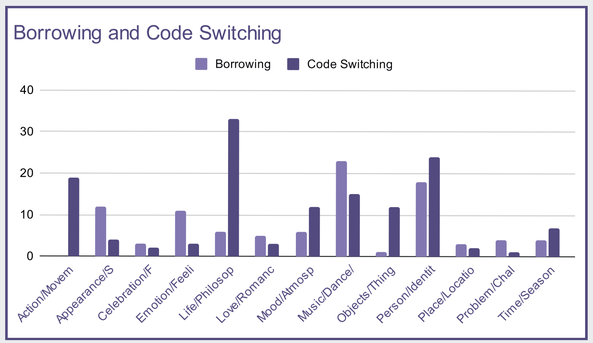


Figure 3: Distribution of Borrowing and Code Switching across Semantic Categories

Discussion

Functions of Code-Switching in Bollywood Lyrics

- Modernity & Global Identity: English in Person/Identity and Music/Dance domains signals cosmopolitanism. "English in Indian film songs often serves as a marker of modernity and international outlook." (Chamundeshwari & Iqbal, 2019).
- Register Variation: Strategic English deployment signals shifts in tone and emotional register.
- Audience Awareness: English incorporation reflects Bollywood's global reach and urban Indian youth's bilingual proficiency.

Grammatical Integration Patterns

- Nominal Dominance: Nouns (37.8%) follow typical lexical borrowing patterns.
- Functional Elements: High pronoun presence (34.1%) indicates "intra-sentential code-switching" within clause boundaries.
- Verbal Integration: Verbs demonstrate complex morphosyntactic adaptation through "composite verbs" (e.g.,"try karna").

Language Evolution: The patterns observed may signal ongoing changes in Hindi, particularly in urban contexts where English influence is strongest, potentially leading to the emergence of what some scholars termed "Hinglish", a distinct linguistic variety.

Conclusion

English incorporation in Bollywood song lyrics follows systematic patterns that reflect both linguistic constraints and socio-cultural motivations:

- The predominance of code-switching over borrowing suggests deliberate communicative strategies
- English elements serve multiple functions beyond mere lexical necessity
- The concentration in specific semantic domains (Person/Identity, Linguistic Expression, Music/Dance) reflects cultural priorities.

Limitations: Small sample size (36 songs, 233 words)

- Subjective judgment in distinguishing between borrowing and code-switching and the distribution of semantic categories.

Future Research Directions:

- Diachronic analysis examining changes over different decades
- Audience reception studies
- Comparative analysis with other Indian film industries

References

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